Burners playtest

Changes since October 15.

Initiative

When the Referee says “roll initiative!”, roll your level plus your empty slots (up to 4) in d6s and leave them on the table as they land. These dice are your Fuel: you burn them to attack, Defend, and cast.

Your Initiative is how many show 3 or 4. The Referee does the same for the monsters. Match or beat their count and you go before them; fall short and you go after. Before or after, players act in any order they like. Going first, your whole Action is yours then: move, strike, cast, or hold some of it until something happens.

Each round after, the Referee says “roll initiative!” again. Drop the dice you don’t want, roll back up to your level plus empty slots, and count the 3s and 4s again.

Damage

When you attack, you do your weapon’s slots in damage. You may burn up to one Fuel on top of that. Subtract the monster’s AC and count up the damage you deal. When the total reaches the monster’s HP it goes down.

Your weapon does 1 instead of its slots if you don’t have its Trait, or if it’s a two-handed weapon wielded in one hand. Your Trait must precisely match your weapon and not a general category: “arming sword” or “longsword”, not “sword”.

The Referee will make the monster’s HP and AC visible to you, at least when you deal damage first, if not before.

Friction

Some moves are hard to pull off, so you burn one Fuel to try them, and you can’t burn again. If a foe counters with more Fuel, the action fails or goes awry.

Drawing under pressure. Burn one Fuel to draw or pick up a weapon with a foe in reach.

Unarmed vs armed. Burn one Fuel to make an unarmed attack against an armed opponent.

Tight spaces. Burn one Fuel if you don’t have room to swing your weapon.

Standing up. Burn one Fuel to rise from the dirt with a foe pressing you in melee.

In the line of fire. An attack normally hits whatever is first in its line: friend, foe, or wall. Burn a 6 on the attack to shoot, strike, or cast past it: into a melee, from the second rank, around a cart or the shield wall in front of their sorcerer.

Defend

When you are hit, you may burn Fuel to reduce the damage. You can burn only one die unless your Action this round matches the threat. If you attacked or blocked in melee, burn as many as you like against melee blows; if you shot, against missiles; if you cast, against spells.

Special attacks. If your Defend cancels all the damage, the blow never touches you and its special attack fails: no poison, no level drain, no grab. You were not “hit”.

Armor. When hit, reduce the damage by your armor class (AC), if any. Armor doesn’t stop touch or special attacks: unless your Defend cancelled all the damage, they still take effect, even if armor soaks the rest.

Block

You can now Block a blow aimed at you, not just one aimed at an adjacent ally. It still spends an attack.

Training. Each shield, sword, or parrying dagger you’re trained in takes its slots off a blow you Block, without burning Fuel, just as training adds slots to damage. With a sword and shield, add both.

Magic

Arcana training. If you’re trained in the Arcana you cast with (a *staff*, *wand*, or *orb* Trait), add its slots to your cast total, whether the spell does damage or not. It adds to a Ward too. One Arcana per action.

Enchanted gear. An enchanted weapon or shield you’re trained in adds a die to your attack or Defend once a round: burn a second Fuel die, or roll a free one. The free die isn’t Fuel, so you can’t pick its face: some rounds the magic sings, some rounds it barely wakes. A Spark can sometimes trigger a special ability; this takes experimentation or a *Read Magic* spell from a sorcerer knowledgeable in such things.

Dropped rules

Burning a 1 to add an item’s slots. The two-hander’s second die. The Handguard tag. Dividing damage by 5. A melee foe as Cover.

Approach Traits

A Journeyman can now take *longbow* and *staff* under Craft. A Boss can now take *rod* and *mace* under Heart.

Each Trait belongs to one Approach and covers only that Approach's use. A Sorcerie *staff* is Arcana, not a weapon; to fight with it, take *staff* under Craft.

Crossovers

Some items have a Trait under two Approaches, one for each use. Take a level in both Approaches and the Trait under each, and one item does both jobs.

- *Staff*. Under Sorcerie it's your Arcana: its slots add to your casts and Wards. Under Craft it's a fighting staff: its slots add to your blows.
- *Rod*. Under Sorcerie, Arcana. Under Heart, a Boss's weapon.
- *Mask*. Under Sorcerie, Arcana. Under Craft, a disguise.
- *Signet ring*. Under Sorcerie, Arcana. Under Heart, your seal, for trading, bargaining, and pulling rank.

A mace under Sword and under Heart is the same use, a weapon, so it isn't a crossover. Take it once.

Fatigue

In a long fight, fatigue fills one of your empty slots, then another, as you tire. A day without food or a night without sleep fills one too. With no empty slot, drop something to make room. Rest, food, and sleep clear it.

Referee

Monster initiative. The Referee rolls the monsters' highest Hit Die plus 4 in d6s (fewer for slow ones), and counts the 3s and 4s. Those dice are the monsters' Fuel: one pool for the whole group, topped up each round like yours. The Referee spends it to bolster any monster's attack or Defend, so the boss, or the one with the upper hand, hits harder.

Monster damage. A monster hits for its Hit Dice or its weapon's slots, whichever suits it. The Referee rolls a d6 with each attack: a 6 Sparks, adding 6 to the damage, or, for a monster with a special attack, triggering it instead (poison, a grab, a knockdown). Giants and other freakishly strong monsters roll 2d6, so they Spark more often.